civil and the military officers posted in NEFA at the time, was that the events of the past year were all a ploy to give China the bargaining chips it needed to get India to yield to its claim on Aksai Chin. In messes and clubs, people argued that after all Peking had accepted the demarcation of the watershed to delineate the boundaries with Burma, Nepal, Bhutan and Sikkim.

In August 1960, there were reports of a Chinese party having come to a remote monastery in the desolate and bleak area between Bum-la and the Nyamjang Chu Valley that lay to its west. Palit decided to do a detailed reconnaissance of the Tawang salient and he duly set off for Khenzemane via the traditional route that ran from Tawang to Lumla and then north towards the border along the river.

At Zimithang, the valley broadened considerably. The post commander pointed out the stark silhouette of a long flat spur high above to the west. This was Lumpu, a summer habitation for semi-nomadic goatherds who visited the region to graze their animals on the slopes of the Thagla and even across the ridge on the Tibetan side. Proceeding further forward, Palit noted the vulnerability of both the Assam Rifles posts at Chutangmu and Khenzemane for they were located at the bottom of deep valleys that were completely dominated by the heights around them. Backtracking to Zimithang, Palit and his party climbed the near vertical path to the 15,700-foot Chamling-la before proceeding to the Gompa at Taksang (referred to as the T-Gompa by army officers today). There the party spent the night. The head lama confirmed that a party of five Chinese had indeed forced their way in a few days ago. Palit found out that the Chinese had crossed the boundary at a place that he had previously believed to be inaccessible. Now that he realized that there was access via many game trails, he came away convinced that Bum-la, and even Tawang situated further below, were not suitable defensive positions.

Having mentally downgraded the military potential of Bum-la-Tawang Palit decided that the answer lay in fortifying Se-la as a defensive position. The sheer imposing look of Se-la beguiled him into believing that Thorat’s defensive line needed to be pushed up from Bomdila–Manda-la to Se-la.

Needing a lot more information, Palit immediately dispatched his DQ, Major Raja Fulay, to reconnoitre Se-la’s surroundings. Before Fulay could report back, however, Palit was posted to Army HQ ‘with immediate